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The War on Drugs, Intelligence Reform, and Mixed Ethics

INTRODUCTION

The “forever war” on drugs (WOD) has stirred international criticism due to its U.S.-centric approach, prolonged engagement, and controversial outcomes. Despite the vast resources allocated to this effort, the loosely defined success metrics have led to intense debate in public and foreign policy circles. This paper examines how aggressive intelligence collection strategies, framed as offensive intelligence, have resulted in domestically and internationally unintended consequences. The intelligence community (IC) has prioritized counter-narcotics operations, embedding them deeply within intelligence analysis and policy-making frameworks. The cultural, political, and economic impacts of the WOD reach beyond American borders, influencing foreign perceptions and creating humanitarian challenges. Intelligence analysis drives these policies, or “the process of interpreting collected information to address current operations or predict future behavior” (Tingstad 9). Yet, its politicization and secrecy undermine public trust and, ultimately, policy efficacy (Tingstad 9).

The WOD has often been approached with a "hawkish" strategy, marked by international intelligence alliances (Five Eyes), technology investments, and covert operations. This approach has intensified issues such as anti-U.S. sentiment abroad, which paradoxically fuels criminal networks and the drug trade itself. Moreover, the structure of the IC, with frequent turnover, data

conflicts, and rapid deployments, has often compromised objective analysis, leading to reactive rather than preventive strategies, according to a 2023 ODNI annual report (ODNI 21).

To address these increasingly present issues, this paper will outline six strategic steps toward intelligence reform, with the key one advocating for a shift from offensive intelligence to an apolitical and evidence-based framework. These frameworks are applied through a mixed deontological, consequential, and virtue-ethical lens approach. Intelligence work does not allow for a universal moral compass, as a rules-based approach or a consequence-based mode of ethics, includes limitations (Phillips 8). However, universal consequentialism is especially emphasized in the need for defensive policymaking and objective intelligence to restore trust and prioritize the needs of U.S. citizens, global partners, and national security. Understanding the historical and ethical foundations of the WOD is essential to these proposed reforms.

HISTORY/CONCEPTS

The origins of the U.S. intelligence effort traced back to the American Revolution, where intelligence was initially employed for defensive purposes during times of war or national threat, such as the conflict with Great Britain. By the late 19th century, with rising foreign threats and growing militarism, intelligence agencies began to take shape (Tidd, 2008, 5). Over the decades, intelligence evolved to play a crucial role in shaping U.S. foreign and domestic policy, particularly after World War II and in the Cold War era. Post-1960s, intelligence agencies began adopting a more offensive approach. This was particularly influenced by the Nixon administration's "tough-on-crime" mentality, leading to more proactive intelligence-gathering strategies both internationally and domestically (Britannica 1).

In this case, the consequentialist ethical question becomes: Do the outcomes of intelligence-gathering tactics during the WOD lead to greater overall benefit for national security, or do they cause more harm?

A key example that can be examined in the discussion of intelligence reform is the USA PATRIOT Act, enacted in the aftermath of the 9/11 attacks. The Act significantly expanded the scope of intelligence tools previously used in the WOD, allowing authorities to gather more information on individuals without judicial oversight (U.S. Department of Justice 2). Notably, the National Security Letters (NSLs) provision permits the government to obtain “sensitive personal information,” which includes but is not limited to “phone records, banking details, and internet history,” all without needing a court order (ACLU 1). The ACLU states that “only fifteen of those cases—a microscopic 0.8%—involved terrorism”, while the rest were related to drugs or fraud. This raises concerns about the effectiveness of the PATRIOT Act, especially considering its broad focus on both drug enforcement and counterterrorism. The low number of terrorism-related cases suggests that the application of the Act to drug cases might not align with its original counterterrorism objectives. Furthermore, given the limited convictions for terrorism-related offenses, it’s worth questioning whether the substantial state resources spent on these efforts have been justified.

From a consequentialist perspective, ethics can be analyzed by deciding if expansive surveillance outweighs potential harm. Proponents argue that expanded intelligence tools provide a deterrent against terrorism and drug trafficking, potentially protecting national security and reducing crime. However, critics point out that the actual outcomes, such as the low number of drug and terror-related convictions, suggest that the harm (e.g., erosion of privacy, wrongful surveillance of innocent individuals, potential racial profiling) may outweigh the benefits.

Additionally, its previously described high rate of failure in turning over drug traffickers can be considered a waste of resources, such as in payment for technology, personnel, and overall intelligence collection efforts. While these efforts may be justified if focused on terrorism, the significant diversion of resources toward drug enforcement calls into question whether this dual focus is the most effective use of intelligence resources. The intelligence collection resources could be redirected to more targeted, effective measures.

The sneak-and-peek searches, another provision of the PATRIOT Act, allow intelligence agencies to enter private property 'without prior notice or consent' (ACLU 5). In 2010, '76% of these searches were related to drug enforcement, with fewer than 1% linked to terrorism, and none resulting in convictions' (ACLU 5). This raises further questions about the proportionality of the tactics and their effectiveness in achieving the intended outcomes. Additionally, the technology, combined with looser investigative restrictions, makes domestic surveillance so easy that it raises concerns about widespread privacy violations. There is evidence suggesting that this ease of surveillance may lead to improper investigations of innocent individuals, compromising their privacy rights without just cause.

Even more so, there is evidence suggesting that domestic surveillance, including facial recognition, has led to the wrongful identification of innocent individuals. A separate study conducted by the ACLU highlights how misidentifications can have significant consequences. For example, in one case, a man was wrongfully arrested for shoplifting based on a facial recognition match, despite having no connection to the crime. This misuse is not isolated; facial recognition technology has been found to make incorrect matches with a significant percentage of people, particularly people of color. One report found that in Florida alone, even if misidentifications occurred only once per thousand searches, that would result in eight wrongful

implications per month (ACLU 5). While finding studies on PATRIOT Act convictions is difficult due to classification, connecting these private sector surveillance mistakes can reveal similar problems in governmental investigations.

Consequentialism also considers whether the long-term effects of intelligence practices during the War on Drugs (WOD) contribute to the overall well-being of society. Surveillance measures lead to a decline in public trust, fears of government overreach, or violations of human rights. However, despite these concerns, empirical evidence shows that public support for the intelligence community (IC) remains relatively stable. This could be due to the framing of surveillance practices as essential for national security, a lack of transparency about their reach, and the perceived benefits of safety and crime reduction (Madden and Raine 6). While privacy concerns persist, many individuals may not see the immediate effects of surveillance, which allows public trust to endure (Madden and Raine 4). Key events, such as the 2013 Snowden leaks, brought public awareness to the scale of surveillance under the Patriot Act (Center for Democracy and Technology). The revelations about bulk data collection and other secret surveillance programs triggered widespread concerns about privacy and civil liberties. This not only heightened fear of government overreach but also led to significant efforts to reform surveillance laws, as seen with the passage of the USA FREEDOM Act in 2015, which aimed to curb some of the more intrusive aspects of the Patriot Act (Pascual 4). Additionally, this general public's "awareness of being watched can intensify existing distrust, paranoia, and fear" (National Library of Medicine 14). This same distrust, paranoia, and fear can in turn raise national security concerns of domestic upheaval. On the other hand, if these measures are shown to have a significant deterrent effect on drug trafficking and cause increased trust in the public sector, their ethical justification may be stronger. The challenge, from a consequentialist

standpoint, is determining whether the benefits of these intelligence measures truly outweigh the social and ethical costs.

The methodology of this research is primarily qualitative, involving historical analysis, policy review, and the examination of open-source intelligence (OSINT), including government reports and non-governmental organization (NGO) assessments. Data from sources such as the U.S. Department of State, Amnesty International, and the ACLU were used to provide a broad understanding of the consequences of intelligence practices. However, the research is limited by the absence of case studies that examine the long-term impacts of intelligence reform and drug enforcement across different geographical and political contexts. Intelligence is often a tightly controlled domain and much of the data required to fully assess the effects of these strategies remains classified or inaccessible to the public.

It is important to note that private-sector involvement in intelligence, such as surveillance technologies provided by private satellite companies, introduces a growing challenge to both transparency and the ethical assessment of intelligence practices. As technologies such as artificial intelligence (AI) become increasingly integral to intelligence collection, the ethical debate intensifies and becomes publicized. While the benefits of AI-driven intelligence gathering could lead to more efficient and targeted enforcement of drug laws, they also raise concerns about privacy, algorithmic bias, and the potential for excessive surveillance.

In conclusion, critiques of U.S. intelligence practices, particularly in the context of the WOD and intelligence reform, are essential for safeguarding civil liberties and ensuring that policies are truly achieving their intended goals. While national security concerns often justify the expansion of surveillance powers, consequentialist ethics asks whether these actions produce the greatest good for society. If the harms, including privacy violations and potential overreach,

outweigh the benefits, such as reduced crime or enhanced national security, then the ethical justification for such practices becomes questionable. Ongoing debates and reforms are necessary to ensure that intelligence practices serve the public good without compromising fundamental rights.

WAR ON DRUGS

The domestic policy advisor under President Nixon, when discussing the war on drugs, had stated that “we knew we couldn’t make it illegal to be either against the war or black, but by getting the public to associate the hippies with marijuana and blacks with heroin, and then criminalizing both heavily, we could disrupt those communities. We could arrest their leaders, raid their homes, break up their meetings, and vilify them night after night on the evening news. Did we know we were lying about the drugs? Of course, we did” (Brennan Center for Justice 5). This politicization of the WOD, and in turn the intelligence supporting the WOD, was not only clearly stated by chief advisors, but can also be seen through the lens of intelligence analysis. This politicization of intelligence was later solidified by Nixon’s primarily Republican appointment of intelligence officers and Department of Defense leadership.

In 1971, when President Nixon declared an official 'War on Drugs,' the administration framed the rise of medicinal and recreational drug use as a rapidly escalating national security threat (Pascual 8). However, these concerns were not just about public health or safety; they were deeply tied to Nixon's political strategy. Nixon’s rhetoric around the drug issue was part of his broader efforts to galvanize conservative support, particularly through his 'Southern Strategy,' which used the criminalization of drug use to target minority communities and dissident groups (Brennan Center for Justice 3). This framing turned a growing societal issue into a political

weapon. Nixon's conservative ideals were enforced in his policy plans of combatting the war on drugs, stating that "drug abuse was now 'public enemy number one'" (Pascual). These political advisories placed pressure on intelligence analysts to provide in-depth intelligence about demographic groups, specifically minorities, about drug use. The specifics of these intelligence collection methods (e.g., wiretapping, surveillance satellites) and directives (e.g., policies expanding the role of intelligence agencies), coincided with evolving technology. A major issue with these policy plans is that the WOD was never implemented with long-term solutions or foreign policy ideas in mind, along with being based on politicized intelligence analysis. As mentioned previously, politicized intelligence analysis provides one-sided data and collection of information during the intelligence gathering cycle. Over 50 years later, the WOD is a debate that is seen in current presidential campaigns and voter recruitment strategies.

Despite this passage of time, these same national security threats and goals surrounding drug use remain increasingly prevalent, with the WOD often considered unsuccessful by many scholars and critics. However, policymakers who implemented these policies, particularly during Nixon's administration, often viewed the WOD as a success in terms of political support and achieving short-term public safety goals, despite its long-term failure to reduce drug use or address the social consequences of mass incarceration (Pascual 5). For example, in the last 40 years, "the number of people convicted of drug-related crimes has risen more than 500 percent, now making up almost half of the federal prison population," which has crippling effects on re-entry, the poverty cycle, and local crime statistics (Tierney 4). From a consequentialist perspective, the lack of justifiability for the failure of the WOD is a greater detriment than the greater good for the general public and national security.

DOMESTIC U.S.

Aside from the PATRIOT Act's ability to access civilian files, the Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA) holds a unique project that was held in greater secrecy: the Hemisphere Project, also referred to as Data Analytical Services, or DAS (ACLU). DAS served as an extension of the PATRIOT Act, furthering its ability to track the location, time, and extent of phone calls and other private data (ACLU 12). The increased capabilities of domestic intelligence services raised many concerns, especially from civil liberties groups, who previously claimed that the PATRIOT Act was unconstitutional (ACLU 13). The advocacy groups claim that this surveillance violates the Fourth Amendment, which prohibits unreasonable searches and seizures (ACLU 12). The Department of Justice rebukes these claims, but both sides ignore a wider gap of transparency and the systemic offensive approach to crime.

DAS represents a significant issue of transparency within the Intelligence Community (IC), as the DEA intentionally kept the program under the radar by not referencing it in government documents and providing minimal details about its scope. This lack of transparency can erode public trust, even though many citizens might not suspect the government is engaged in such activities. However, studies show that when citizens are kept in the dark about surveillance programs, it fosters a sense of insecurity, which diminishes trust in the government (ACLU 13). For example, a report by the ACLU highlights how secrecy surrounding surveillance programs leads to growing concerns about unchecked government power and potential civil liberties violations (ACLU 13). Additionally, the lack of oversight and accountability in such programs allows the government to operate without public scrutiny, fueling mistrust (National Security Archive 12). Greater transparency surrounding intelligence collection leads to a healthy democracy that not only increases trust in the U.S. government on a

domestic scale but internationally as well. Transparency allows citizens to hold the USG accountable for its intelligence collection failures and provides a better look into the legal system. Especially as the domestic and international community continues to grow dependent on digital means, the transparency and scope of digital privacy require efforts to evolve. Further information regarding the geographical areas of focus and the previous failures of these acts opens up valuable areas of research for scholars, potentially uncovering improvements that might otherwise be overlooked by a strictly governmental perspective. However, from a consequentialist standpoint, providing such transparency would also need to consider the costs. Divulging the details of surveillance programs could compromise their effectiveness, allowing adversaries to adjust their tactics. Thus, while greater transparency is vital for accountability, the potential risks of undermining national security through the disclosure of sensitive information must also be weighed in the evaluation of these programs (Franklin et al. 32).

The PATRIOT Act and DAS are examples of an offensive over defensive approach to intelligence collection. A problem with this approach regarding domestic WOD is the increased systemic discrimination of minorities and those with low-income backgrounds. The advisor to Nixon had previously discussed its blatantly racist origins, and the statistics are overwhelming evidence. For example, the NAACP has reported that African Americans “represent 5% of the country’s total drug users, but make up 33% of those incarcerated for a drug offense,” alongside a vast amount of other literature citing the discriminatory US criminal justice system (Burch 17). From a consequentialist lens, furthering systemic racist measures is not only worse for national security but also for the minorities that its surveillance is directly harming. “Tough-on-crime” and punitive measures, such as these and more, further these structural racist models by having discriminatory data that often points to a guilty until proven innocent-intelligence mentality.

From a legal or deontological perspective, a fair trial for an individual facing criminal prosecution is jeopardized if data is unfairly and illegitimately collected from that surveillance data.

Additionally, the PATRIOT Act and DAS represent a military-focused, intelligence-based, and politicized solution to wider issues, in this case, public health problems. The politicized realm of the WOD can be shown by various factors, with the main one being the “Southern Strategy,” which is a campaign strategy employed by Nixon. Under this strategy, Nixon sought to increase poor White Southern people's recruitment to the Republican Party, in part by demonizing and weaponizing an already alleged enemy to the South: African-Americans and immigrants (Burch 17). The strategy encouraged the poor White South to see people of color and low-income individuals as “criminals, drug-addicted, and receivers of government largesse (i.e. welfare) at the expense of rural whites” (Burch 17). This politicized approach to the WOD not only impacted public perception and support for punitive measures but also created an environment that fostered the start of offensive intelligence collection and set the blueprint for the PATRIOT Act/DAS.

An unaddressed problem by the CIA surrounding the WOD is the alleged reports and conspiracy theories of the CIA secretly supporting the WOD. According to a 1993 confession by a former DEA undercover agent, “without CIA support, South American cartels and the epidemic of cocaine and crack use in the U.S. would never have occurred” (U.S. Department of Justice 1). This controversy continues, with the U.S. Department of Justice also posting a news article that states a “drug ring sold tons of cocaine to the Crips and Bloods street gangs of Los Angeles and funneled millions in drug profits to a Latin American guerrilla army run by the U.S. Central Intelligence Agency” (U.S. Department of Justice 1). Other media organizations claim

that this conspiracy is false, but state the CIA instead exercised complicity in drug flow into the U.S. (Office of the Inspector General 9). Although conspiracy, this controversy is important to note as it consequently decreases public trust within the IC and remains relatively unacknowledged by the USG. Additionally, this controversy raised international concern over the legal and ethical consequences of the U.S. being complicit in a war that revolutionized modern surveillance technology and usage.

INTELLIGENCE REFORM

The call for intelligence reform in the United States is a delicate balance between protecting national security interests and maintaining the privacy rights of its inhabitants. I call for six main forms of intelligence reform, that are not exhaustive of the intensive attention necessary for proper improvement. First, and namely most important, is a defensive over offensive policymaking approach. An offensive national security approach focuses on actively aiming to change the political environment to maintain dominance or control while a defensive national security approach focuses on proactive risk mitigation and reactive approach. Second, a focus on foreign reconstruction in countries that the U.S. has previously supported in military or humanitarian aid. The continued oversight and adaptation of humanitarian aid, especially in support of public services, is recommended, especially in the investment of local NGOs or organizations. Third, is the avoidance of overclassification of national security material. The organization and transparency between the IC are necessary for improved policy support. Fourth is the diversification of funding, especially from military support to rehabilitation and internal support. Fifth, is the mandatory improved training on cultural awareness and education on language skills. Diplomats and intelligence analysts who are further educated on the cultural notes of foreign entities are better equipped to succeed. The sixth, which ties into the fifth

recommendation, is a diversified workforce. The commitment and plan to include diverse voices and outlooks guarantee a well-rounded intelligence analysis.

In the era of globalization, the U.S. must adopt a predominantly defensive policymaking and intelligence strategy to navigate the complex web of international relations and secure its long-term national security. A defensive approach prevents the alienation of foreign nations and fosters cooperative global relationships, addressing the growing concern of international public opinion on the United States. Historically, the offensive approach has often resulted in unintended consequences, casting the U.S. as imperialist in regions where it has intervened militarily or financially. As the Institute of World Politics observes, the U.S.'s offensive foreign policy reflects an “expansion of inherent American values and historical virtues” on an international scale, particularly in areas unfamiliar with such ideals (Tierney 15). However, this projection of values can backfire, perpetuating a security dilemma: efforts to enhance U.S. security provoke fear and countermeasures in other states, ultimately diminishing the U.S.'s security (Britannica 3).

The Cold War’s geopolitical dynamics heavily influenced the hawkish nature of U.S. foreign policy. While these strategies may have been justified during a bipolar power struggle, the WOD is less about national security and more about political maneuvering. For example, President Nixon's WOD policies were designed to solidify popular vote/electoral support, rather than combat communism or drug trafficking effectively (Pascual 15). This politically motivated offensive approach not only lacked ethical or intelligence-based grounding, as evaluated through virtue ethics, but also harmed U.S. credibility both domestically and internationally.

A shift toward restraint and defensive policymaking is necessary as international political atmospheres tighten. In this case, offensive realism, which theorizes that real powers secure themselves by maximizing power risks alienating allies and fostering distrust (Grafov 7). Instead, the U.S. should prioritize strategies that enhance public diplomacy, which directly influences global public opinion, which is a key determinant of national security. Public diplomacy is a method that needs to be further researched, not only for the sake of U.S. national security but also for the human intelligence analysis of human rights violations conducted by the U.S. in countries it has intervened in. Foreign public opinion policy serves as an open realm to deal with how public policy aligns with policy needs. For example, the WOD exemplifies how a lack of focus on public diplomacy has damaged U.S. credibility and strained international relations, particularly in Latin America, where interventions have been viewed as imperialistic and counterproductive. This feedback loop will only cascade into larger drug concerns in the future. Funding for public diplomacy areas of research and intelligence would bridge the current research gap that is desperately needed.

Next, a common reference in the literature review community is the lack of organization within the intelligence community, despite historical IC reforms for better communication. A smaller part of the literature community discusses the issues of overclassification, which decreases transparency and is a subsector of the miscommunication issues. Avril Haines, former Deputy Director of the CIA, stated that overclassification “negatively impacts national security” (National Security Archive 13). Analysts processing data at varying classification levels may interpret the same issue massively differently, with different data levels. With information that is not overly detrimental to U.S. national security and proper security clearance tracking involved, declassifying this data to lower levels correlates to conclusions that are widely found.

Additionally, overclassification decreases the overall trust that the public has in the government, which is shown today through social cohesion and increasing bipartisan divisions. Therefore, updates need to be made to the declassification processes, which include the collaboration between the many IC agencies. Classified systems need to be synched in digital environments, and labeled by classification level and agency production. With the recent scandals regarding former President Donald Trump highlighting insecurities in the classification realm, there is a systematic urgency with reforms. Leaked data, especially due to lack of care from government officials, serves as a ground for further distrust within the USG and its citizens, harming national security. In the case of the WOD, the controversial Edward Snowden leaks surrounding mass surveillance included aspects of the DEA's tactics. Streamlining classification processes and fostering inter-agency collaboration could have improved the intelligence community's ability to address the complexities of the drug trade and its societal impact. Additionally, the government spends "exorbitantly more on classification as opposed to declassifying material" (National Security Archives 35). This funding on classification can be focused on security clearance maintenance, or divested. Overall, more precise and well-rounded intelligence analysis correlates with how policymakers are briefed, therefore dictating how a conclusion that may affect millions is made.

Diversification of funding toward internal services also better guarantees the future of domestic national security. From a WOD perspective, where nearly 1 in 5 is locked up for a drug offense, a rehabilitative approach to crime can decrease crime rates, allowing organizations to focus time on other national security concerns (Drug Policy Alliance 9). In 2021, taxpayers spent \$3.3 billion funding the DEA, the primary intelligence organization for the WOD (Drug Policy Alliance 9). Rehabilitation saves money for the USG and reduces recidivism by around 10%

(Davidson 21). Additionally, diversification of funding to programs such as rehabilitation creates room for focus on cultural awareness training.

Improved training on cultural awareness for analysts/diplomats provides the knowledge necessary to bridge cultural gaps. Education on cultural sensitivity can prevent mistakes of accidental insults when working with foreign professionals. Nuances of global interactions can create tensions between government officials that leak into the diplomatic work of countries. Further discussions on prohibiting implicit biases of another culture, and examining the analysts/diplomats' reasons for a specific area of focus are necessary for long-term diplomacy. Diplomacy, in turn, is related to national security and the state of foreign relations. Additionally, proper language training that acknowledges what is “lost in translation,” with a focus on proper pronunciation is important to the development of healthy diplomatic relationships. From an intelligence analyst's perspective, the misunderstanding of a translated term without understanding the nuances of a specific term can lead to catastrophic consequences in terms of intel interpretation. Language in diplomacy and analysis influences connections, negotiations, and persuasions, especially in cases of peace talks (Diplo 7). Improved cultural awareness and language training could aid public diplomacy by fostering stronger diplomatic relationships with foreign partners in regions heavily affected by the WOD/drug trade networks, such as Latin America.

The final step is the suggestion of a diversified workforce within the intelligence community, government, and foreign service alike. Not only would a diversified workforce acknowledge the disparities that marginalized communities face in the U.S., but also commit to national security safety. A diverse IC can analyze intelligence, including WOD ethical lenses, from fresh perspectives that can be especially culturally aware. Additionally, diversity can filter

out failures or harsh intelligence analyses, especially in terms of what is or is not covered in an assessment or briefing. Having briefings and intelligence that cover a wide variety of topics can be useful in combating biases that only focus on topics that an analyst may be aware of.

Additionally, including underrepresented groups can help build trust with communities most affected by the WOD, improving collaboration/policy outcomes. Finally, a diverse workforce can create a community that feels safe for all backgrounds and discourage discriminatory behavior in the workplace.

CONCLUSION

The War on Drugs underscores the urgent need for U.S. intelligence reform. Forever wars such as the WOD have exposed systemic issues within the intelligence and policy apparatus of the United States, highlighting the moral and operational limitations of offensive, interventionist strategies. The failures of these approaches, often shrouded in secrecy, point to a deeper need for reform based on ethical principles and transparency.

From a deontological perspective, which emphasizes the adherence to ethical duties and principles, intelligence reform is not only a practical necessity but a moral obligation. This framework insists that intelligence practices respect individual rights, adhere to principles of justice, and avoid harm, regardless of their outcomes. Such an approach calls for the intelligence community to align its methods with core ethical duties: respect for privacy, upholding the rule of law and preventing discriminatory practices. Under this view, the means of intelligence collection are as crucial as the ends, and intelligence policies must avoid treating certain populations as mere instruments in the pursuit of national security.

Deontological ethics thus argues for a shift from hawkish offensive intelligence strategies to defensively oriented policies that respect fundamental rights and avoid harm to both American

citizens and foreign populations. In today's international climate, where anti-U.S. sentiment is prevalent, a reevaluation of intelligence practices' human consequences is imperative.

Intelligence reform should focus on long-term, principled commitments to transparency, responsible oversight, and ethical engagement with global partners. This reform agenda includes prioritizing foreign reconstruction efforts in areas affected by U.S. intervention, avoiding overclassification, diversifying funding toward rehabilitative programs, training intelligence personnel in cultural awareness, and fostering a more diverse intelligence workforce. These steps are not just practical; they are ethical commitments that require the U.S. intelligence community to operate under standards that respect dignity, uphold justice, and maintain public trust.

Ultimately, intelligence reform is more than internal restructuring; it is a cultural and ethical reassessment of how the United States interacts with the world and manages its security interests. By embedding intersectional ethical principles within the intelligence community, U.S. policymakers and intelligence analysts can better align national security with the ethical expectations of both U.S. citizens and global communities.

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